

Figures of Speech Quick Revision

The night-before pass: tricks and the 10-second method, the high-yield confusions, and the final revision sheet.

36 figures explained **25** syllabus poems analysed **971** poem quotations checked word for word **144** practice questions

Faster than fairies, faster than witches,

From a Railway Carriage · Robert Louis Stevenson

Alliteration f...f...f

Simile a comparison with “than”

Hyperbole no train beats fairies

One line, three figures — this book teaches you to spot each one.

7 Tricks and the 10-Second Method

This section turns the whole book into quick tools: one mnemonic, a 10-step method, a clue-word dictionary, a trick for every figure, four worked lines with many figures, and an exam-day checklist.

7.1 The master mnemonic

MEMORY TRICK: "A Smart Monkey Plays On A Rainy Rocky Road" = Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme scheme, Rhyming words — the 9 figures named in the 2022 syllabus.

Picture a clever monkey playing on a wet, stony road. Each word gives the first letter of one figure, in this order:

Letter	Word	Figure
A	A	Alliteration (3.1)
S	Smart	Simile (3.2)
M	Monkey	Metaphor (3.3)
P	Plays	Personification (3.4)
O	On	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
A	A	Anaphora (3.6)
R	Rainy	Repetition (3.7)
R	Rocky	Rhyme scheme (3.8)
R	Road	Rhyming words (3.9)

Two helpers. The two A's are both about the START: Alliteration repeats the first SOUND of words; Anaphora repeats the first WORD of lines. The three R's all deal with things that come back: Repetition brings back words; Rhyme scheme and Rhyming words follow the end-sounds that come back.

For the 4 figures of the earlier syllabus, add "Ask All Old Exams" = Apostrophe, Allusion, Oxymoron, Ellipsis (4.1 to 4.4).

7.2 The 10-Second Method

Go down the ten questions in order; the early ones are the quickest to see. Tick every YES, then match your ticks with the options.

Step	Ask yourself	If yes, it is ...
1	Is there a word that copies a sound (buzz, hiss, click, whistle, snap)?	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
2	Do two or more nearby words begin with the same consonant SOUND?	Alliteration (3.1). A vowel sound repeated inside words = Assonance (4.5); a consonant sound repeated inside or at the end = Consonance (4.6).
3	Is like , as , as ... as or than used to compare two UNLIKE things?	Simile (3.2)
4	Is one thing said to BE another (A is B), with no like or as?	Metaphor (3.3). The same comparison carried through many lines = Extended Metaphor (4.27).
5	Is a thing, an animal or an idea thinking, feeling, speaking or acting like a human?	Personification (3.4)
6	Is the speaker talking TO someone absent or dead, or to a thing or an idea, as if it could hear? (O ..., "River, river, little river!")	Apostrophe (4.1)
7	Is the same word or phrase repeated — at the START of lines? at the END? ANYWHERE?	Only the START of lines, the rest changing: Anaphora (3.6). The END of lines: Epistrophe (4.21); a line or phrase closing every stanza: Refrain (4.22). A whole line said again, or a word repeated anywhere: Repetition (3.7).
8	Are opposites joined — two words side by side? two ideas in balanced halves? a statement that seems absurd but is true?	Oxymoron (4.3) / Antithesis (4.12) / Paradox (4.11)
9	Is there an impossible exaggeration? an understatement with "not"? a soft word for a harsh fact?	Hyperbole (4.7) / Litotes (4.8) / Euphemism (4.9)
10	Is there a reference to a famous person, story or text? Are words left out that you can supply?	Allusion (4.2) / Ellipsis (4.4)

Still no YES? Check the rarer figures in 2.2: a question asked for effect (4.18), Oh! or Alas! (4.19), unusual word order (4.20), many "and"s (4.23), an A B / B A cross (4.24), a part for the whole (4.16).

TRY IT

Line: "She's a lioness; don't mess with her." Step 1: no sound-word. Step 2: no repeated first sound. Step 3: no like, as or than. Step 4: YES — a woman is said to BE a lioness. Steps 5 to 10: nothing more. Answer: **Metaphor** (3.3). When two or more steps say YES, go to 7.5.

7.3 Clue-word dictionary

Spot the clue, then check the meaning. A clue word only points to a figure; it does not prove it.

Clue word or pattern	Points to	Easy example
like as as ... as so ... as as if as though comparing two unlike things	Simile (3.2)	She sings like a koel.
than comparing two unlike things	Simile in textbook keys (3.2); check for Hyperbole too (4.7)	Her voice is sweeter than honey.
"like" as a verb, "as" meaning "when", or like compared with like	NOT a simile	I like mangoes. She is as tall as her brother.
is are was joining two unlike things	Metaphor (3.3)	The classroom was a zoo.
human verbs or feelings for things: smiled wept danced thought	Personification (3.4)	The coconut trees danced in the wind.
O + a name; you said to a thing, an idea or someone absent	Apostrophe (4.1)	O Moon, why do you follow me home?
sound words: buzz hiss click tick-tock sizzle whisper	Onomatopoeia (3.5)	The dosa sizzled on the tawa.
the same first consonant SOUND in nearby words	Alliteration (3.1)	Clever kids keep calm. (c and k: one sound)
the same vowel sound inside nearby words	Assonance (4.5)	The rain in Spain stays mainly in the plain.

Clue word or pattern	Points to	Easy example
the same consonant sound inside or at the end of words	Consonance (4.6)	first and last; odds and ends
the same word or words at the START of lines or clauses, the rest changing	Anaphora (3.6)	Work hard, work honestly, work every day.
the same word or words at the END of lines or clauses	Epistrophe (4.21)	of the people, by the people, for the people
a line or phrase that returns at the end of every stanza	Refrain (4.22)	the chorus of a song
a word repeated anywhere, or a whole line said again, for emphasis	Repetition (3.7)	Rain, rain, go away.
and ... and ... and	Polysyndeton (4.23)	We bought idli and dosa and vada and pongal.
a list with commas and no "and"	Asyndeton (4.23)	I came, I saw, I conquered.
A B / B A criss-cross	Chiasmus (4.24)	Eat to live; do not live to eat.
odd word order, e.g. an adjective, a verb or an object placed before the subject	Inversion (4.20)	Sweet is the mango.
... or words that are understood but missing	Ellipsis (4.4)	Some like tea; others, coffee.
two opposite words side by side	Oxymoron (4.3)	deafening silence; sweet sorrow
opposite ideas in balanced halves	Antithesis (4.12)	Speech is silver, silence is golden.
a statement that sounds absurd but is true	Paradox (4.11)	Less is more.
a short, witty, wise saying	Epigram (4.13)	Brevity is the soul of wit.
a thousand times tons of mountains of forever	Hyperbole (4.7)	I have told you a thousand times!
not or un- used to say a positive gently	Litotes (4.8)	Your coffee is not bad. (= good)
passed away no more and other mild words for harsh facts	Euphemism (4.9)	Grandpa passed away last year.
the opposite of what is said or expected	Irony (4.10); bitter, mocking irony = Sarcasm	"What lovely weather!" said during a cyclone.
one word with two meanings	Pun (4.14)	I used to be a banker, but I lost interest.
a ? that needs no answer	Rhetorical Question (4.18)	Who does not love holidays?
Oh! Alas! Hurrah!	Exclamation (4.19)	Alas! We missed the bus.
a famous name, place, story or text	Allusion (4.2)	He is the Kumbhakarna of our hostel.
a closely linked thing used as the name: crown (= king), kettle (= the water in it)	Metonymy (4.15)	The kettle is boiling.
a part for the whole: hands heads wheels roof	Synecdoche (4.16)	All hands on deck!
an adjective that fits a person, given to a thing: sleepless night busy day	Transferred Epithet (4.17)	I spent a sleepless night before the exam.
words of sight, sound, smell, taste and touch	Imagery (4.26)	the smell of hot sambar and the crunch of a crisp dosa
an object that stands for an idea	Symbolism (4.26)	a dove (= peace); a white flag (= surrender)
steps rising to a peak / a sudden fall to something trivial	Climax / Anticlimax (4.25)	He studied, he passed, he topped the state. / He lost his house, his car and his pencil.
one comparison kept up for many lines; a whole story with a moral	Extended Metaphor / Allegory (4.27)	life as a journey (5.1); a fable (5.4)
the last words of lines sound alike	Rhyming Words (3.9)	star - are; high - sky
letters a, b, c ... for the end-sounds	Rhyme Scheme (3.8)	star, are, high, sky = aabb

7.4 Memory tricks for all 36 figures

Figure	Trick
3.1 Alliteration	ALL-ITERATION: ALL the words start with the same SOUND — say it aloud.
3.2 Simile	Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is".
3.3 Metaphor	Metaphor Means "is": no like, no as — one thing simply IS another.
3.4 Personification	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON.
3.5 Onomatopoeia	ONOMA (name) + POEIA (making): the word makes the very noise it names — buzz, hiss, click.
3.6 Anaphora	ANaphora is At the stArt; EPistrophe is at the End.
3.7 Repetition	Repetition is the parent. Anaphora (start), Epistrophe (end) and Refrain (end of every stanza) are its children, named by WHERE the repeat sits. A whole line said again, like <i>“And miles to go before I sleep”</i> , stays plain Repetition.
3.8 Rhyme Scheme	New end-sound = new letter; same end-sound = same letter.
3.9 Rhyming Words	Trust the ear, not the eye: friend and end rhyme; cough and though do not.
4.1 Apostrophe	APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply.
4.2 Allusion	An ALLUSION ALLUDES (hints) to a famous story or person. Do not mix it up with ILLUSION (a false picture).
4.3 Oxymoron	OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): the word oxymoron is itself an oxymoron.
4.4 Ellipsis	An ELLIPSIS is an ECLIPSE of words: they are hidden, but you know they are there.
4.5 Assonance	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants.
4.6 Consonance	CONSONANCE = CONSONANTS, usually inside or at the end of words (first and last).
4.7 Hyperbole	HYPERbole goes over the top.
4.8 Litotes and Understatement	LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"; UNDERSTATEMENT calls Chennai's May heat "a little warm".
4.9 Euphemism	EUphemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact.
4.10 Irony and Sarcasm	IRONY says the opposite; SARCASM bites — its Greek root means "to tear flesh".
4.11 Paradox	PARA (against) + DOX (opinion): it goes against common sense, yet it is true (Less is more).
4.12 Antithesis	ANTI-thesis: two opposite ideas balanced like a see-saw.
4.13 Epigram	An EPIGRAM is a tiny telegram of wisdom: short, sharp and witty.
4.14 Pun	A PUN is FUN with one word that has two meanings.
4.15 Metonymy	Metonymy = Mention a related thing.
4.16 Synecdoche	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole.
4.17 Transferred Epithet	The night was not sleepless — YOU were.
4.18 Rhetorical Question	A question that carries its own answer: nobody needs to reply.
4.19 Exclamation	EXCLAMATION = a CLAMOUR of feeling: Oh! Alas! Hurrah!
4.20 Inversion	INVERSION turns the order round: "Sweet is the mango", not "The mango is sweet".
4.21 Epistrophe	EPistrophe is at the End.
4.22 Refrain	A REFRAIN REtains like a chorus at the end of every stanza.
4.23 Polysyndeton and Asyndeton	POLY = many "and"s; A = without "and".
4.24 Chiasmus	CHI is the Greek letter X: the words cross over, A B / B A.
4.25 Climax and Anticlimax	CLIMAX (Greek for "ladder") climbs the ladder; ANTICLIMAX falls off the last step.
4.26 Imagery and Symbolism	IMAGERY paints an IMAGE through the five senses; a SYMBOL is a sign for an idea (dove = peace).
4.27 Extended Metaphor and Allegory	An EXTENDED metaphor keeps walking line after line; an ALLEGORY is a whole STORY with a hidden lesson.

7.5 When one line has many figures

Good poetry often packs several figures into one line. List them all, then choose the one the question points to.

*Faster **than** fairies, **faster than** witches,*

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Present: **Alliteration** (the f sound in Faster, fairies, faster, 3.1); **Simile** (the speed is compared with fairies and witches using **than** ; textbook keys count this as a simile, 3.2); **Hyperbole** (no train is really faster than fairies, 4.7); **Repetition** (“faster than” comes twice, 3.7). **Choose:** ALLITERATION is the safest single answer. If Alliteration is not offered, choose Simile. Choose Hyperbole only when the question asks about exaggeration.

River, river, little river!

Bright **you** sparkle on **your** way;

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Present: **Apostrophe** (the poet speaks directly TO the river and calls it "you", as if it could hear, 4.1); **Personification** (the river is treated as a living being going on its way, 3.4); **Repetition** ("river" three times in line 1, 3.7). **Choose:** if an option reads "Apostrophe and Personification", take it. For the address in line 1, choose APOSTROPHE. If Apostrophe is not offered, choose PERSONIFICATION. Choose Repetition only when the question asks about the repeated word.

*We can pull **and** haul **and** push **and** lift **and** drive,*

THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Present: **Polysyndeton** (and ... and ... and ... and, 4.23); **Anaphora** (the line opens with “We can”, and so do the next three lines, such as “We can print and plough and weave and heat and light,”, 3.6); **Personification** (the machines speak as “We”, 3.4); a weak p-alliteration (pull, push) that is not the one to choose. **Choose:** ANAPHORA when two or more “We can” lines are quoted; POLYSYNDETON when only this line is quoted and it is offered, or when the question points to the many “and”s; PERSONIFICATION when the question asks how the machines are presented.

To the gull's way and the whale's way where the wind's like a whetted knife;

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Present: **Simile** (the sharp, cutting wind is compared with a whetted, that is sharpened, knife using **like** , 3.2); **Alliteration** (the w sound in way, whale's, way, where, wind's, whetted, 3.1); **Repetition** ("way" twice, 3.7); **Imagery** (you can feel the wind cut, 4.26). **Choose:** SIMILE when the question is about the wind or the comparison; ALLITERATION when it is about sound or the w-words. If the whole line is quoted, both are offered and the stem gives no hint, choose SIMILE: "like" comparing two unlike things makes it certain. (In the first card the only comparing word was "than", so Alliteration was safer there.)

EXAM TIP: Underline the words the question quotes or points to; the figure it wants lives in those words. When two answers still fit, prefer the one that is beyond doubt (a clear like or as, an O-address, a sound-word, a plain f-f-f) over one you would have to argue for.

7.6 Exam-day checklist

1. Read the stem twice. Is it "identify the figure", "rhyming words", "rhyme scheme", "match", or "which is NOT"?
2. Read the quoted line aloud in your mind: sound figures need the ear, not the eye.
3. Circle the clue words: like, as, than, is, O, I, ?, and ... and, not (7.3).
4. Run the 10-Second Method (7.2) and tick every figure that fits.
5. Match your ticks with the options; choose what the question points to (7.5).
6. Watch the traps: "like" or "as" without an unlike comparison is not a simile; the same LETTER is not always the same SOUND.
7. For a rhyme scheme, write the last word of each line first, then the letters: same end-sound = same letter, new end-sound = new letter.
8. Place the line in its poem (1.2). Knowing the poem's usual figures (Section 5) confirms your answer.

6 Do Not Confuse: High-Yield Pairs

Many wrong answers come from mixing up two look-alike figures. This section puts the 14 most-confused groups side by side. For each group: read the table, see the poem line in action, then learn the one-line trick. Revise the six groups marked **HIGH-FREQUENCY** first. The numbers in the table headings point to the full notes in Sections 3 and 4.

EXAM TIP: When two options both look right, first ask what the line is DOING: comparing, sounding, repeating, contrasting, exaggerating, hinting or referring (the seven families in Section 2). Then use the "Test" row of the tables below to pick the exact figure.

6.1 Simile vs Metaphor HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Simile (3.2)	Metaphor (3.3)
Meaning	An open comparison of two UNLIKE things using a comparing word.	A hidden comparison: one thing is said to BE another thing, with no comparing word.
Clue words	like as as ... as so ... as as if as though than	No comparing word. Often is are was joins two unlike things, or one word is used in a non-literal sense.
Test	Point to the comparing word, then check that it joins two UNLIKE things. Both yes = simile.	Put "like" in the middle. If it still makes sense as a comparison, the original is a metaphor.
Strength	Softer: A is LIKE B - the two stay separate.	Stronger: A IS B - the two become one.
Easy example	Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	Chennai in May is an oven.
From the poems	"Like a child at play." (The River); "And charging along like troops in a battle," (From a Railway Carriage)	"She's a lioness; don't mess with her." (I am Every Woman); "the journey will be joy" (Life)

Your eyes are **like** the diamond bright, but mine are dull **as** lead!

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Simile — two comparing words in one line: eyes **like** diamonds, dull **as** lead. Drop the comparing word ("Your eyes are diamonds") and it turns into a **Metaphor**.

MEMORY TRICK: Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is" - same picture, different grammar.

6.2 Metaphor vs Personification

Basis	Metaphor (3.3)	Personification (3.4)
Meaning	One thing is said to BE another thing - any other thing.	A non-human thing, animal or idea is given human qualities, feelings or actions.
Clue words	"A is B" with a noun that does not literally fit: oven, lioness, bone, children.	Human verbs and adjectives for non-humans: thinks asks smiles whispers sits plays smart
Test	Ask: "A is turned INTO what?" If A is simply called something it is not (an oven, a lioness, a hero), it is a metaphor.	Ask: "Is a non-human doing what only PEOPLE do?" If yes, it is personification.
Easy example	Time is money.	Time waits for no one.
From the poems	"it is bare to the bone." (The House on Elm Street); "And I water'd it in fears," (A Poison Tree - anger is a tree)	"It plays with your mind." (The House on Elm Street); "My little horse must think it queer" (Stopping by Woods)
If both fit	Personification is a special KIND of metaphor - the "other thing" is always a person. If a thing is made human, the exact answer is Personification.	

My computer has always been so **brainy and smart** -

It seems to know **mountains** of information by heart.

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Personification (line 1) — a machine is called **brainy and smart**, like a clever student. **Metaphor** (line 2) — a huge store of facts is called **mountains** (also hyperbole).

MEMORY TRICK: PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON; a metaphor can turn it into ANYTHING.

6.3 Personification vs Apostrophe HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Personification (3.4)	Apostrophe (4.1)
Meaning	Human qualities, feelings or actions are given to a non-human thing, animal or idea. The poet talks ABOUT it.	The poet speaks directly TO someone absent or dead, or to a thing or idea, as if it could hear.

Basis	Personification (3.4)	Apostrophe (4.1)
Clue words	Human actions for a thing, in the third person: it he she they	Calling out and second person: O + a name, you thou , often with !
Test	Is the thing DOING something human while the poet describes it?	Is the thing (or absent person) being CALLED and spoken TO?
Easy example	The moon smiled at the sleeping village.	Twinkle, twinkle, little star, / How I wonder what you are!
From the poems	<i>"He gives his harness bells a shake / To ask if there is some mistake."</i> (Stopping by Woods - the horse acts like a person)	<i>"And, O weary, wandering brother, if contentment you would win,"</i> (The Stick-together Families)
Trap	An apostrophe to a thing usually personifies it too (The River). If both are options, answer what the question focuses on: speaking TO it = Apostrophe.	A listener who is PRESENT is not apostrophe: <i>"Doctor, do you think my tired computer wants a holiday?"</i> (My Computer Needs a Break - the doctor is in the room).

River, river, little river!

Bright **you** sparkle on your way;

O'er the yellow pebbles **dancing**,

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Apostrophe + Personification — the poet calls out to the river and speaks TO it (**you**), though it cannot hear: apostrophe. The river **dancing** over pebbles like a child: personification.

MEMORY TRICK: PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON (talks ABOUT it); APOSTROPHE POSTs a message TO someone who cannot reply.

6.4 Alliteration vs Assonance vs Consonance HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Assonance (4.5)	Consonance (4.6)
Meaning	The same BEGINNING consonant sound in two or more nearby words.	The same VOWEL sound repeated in nearby words.	The same CONSONANT sound repeated, usually inside or at the END of nearby words.
Where in the word	Start	Middle (the vowel)	Middle or end
Test	Say the line aloud: do the FIRST sounds match? Sound, not spelling: city and sun alliterate; cat and city do not.	Do the VOWEL sounds match? Same letter is not enough: cat and cake do not match (short a, long a).	Do the consonant sounds INSIDE or at the END match? If the repeat is only at the start, call it alliteration.
Easy example	Sita sells sweet sundal at the Marina. (s)	Go slow on the road home. (long o)	Lift the gift and shift it left. (ft)
From the poems	<i>"With forward face and reluctant soul;"</i> (Life - f)	<i>"And a grey mist on the sea's face, and a grey dawn breaking."</i> (Sea Fever - long a)	<i>"Of scorching and choking"</i> (On Killing a Tree - ch)
Trap	<i>"Whose woods"</i> is NOT alliteration: whose begins with an h sound.	Count sounds, not spellings: sweep and easy share the long e sound with different letters.	Consonance and assonance often come together in one line - name the one the question points to.

*The only other **sound**'s the **sweep***

*Of **easy** **wind** **and** downy flake.*

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

All three in two lines — **Alliteration:** s at the START (sound's, sweep). **Assonance:** the long e VOWEL inside (sweep, easy). **Consonance:** nd at the END (sound's, wind, and).

MEMORY TRICK: ALL-ITERATION: ALL the words START with the same sound; ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants, mostly at the END.

6.5 Alliteration vs Onomatopoeia

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
Meaning	The same beginning consonant sound repeated in two or more nearby words.	A word that imitates the sound it names.

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
How many words	At least two words are needed.	One word is enough.
Clue words	Any words - only their FIRST sounds matter, not their meaning.	Sound words: buzz click snap whisper whistle groan moan sigh
Test	Say it aloud: do the first sounds repeat?	Close your eyes and say the word: do you HEAR the thing?
Easy example	Priya picked pink petals. (p)	The pressure cooker whistled; the auto horn went honk, honk.
From the poems	"Down you dash into the sea," (The River - d); "So I had to call in a doctor, double quick." (My Computer Needs a Break - d)	"and give my mouse a click," (My Computer Needs a Break); "With buzzing wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew," (The Spider and the Fly)

Speak gently! - *Love* doth *whisper* low

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Both in one line — Onomatopoeia: *whisper* sounds like soft, breathy speech (one word does the job). **Alliteration:** *l* at the start of **Love** and **low** (two words share a first sound). *Love* that *whispers* is also personification.

MEMORY TRICK: Alliteration needs a TEAM of words with the same first sound; onomatopoeia is ONE word that makes the noise itself.

6.6 Repetition vs Anaphora vs Epistrophe vs Refrain HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Repetition (3.7)	Anaphora (3.6)	Epistrophe (4.21)	Refrain (4.22)
Meaning	A word, phrase or line repeated ANYWHERE for emphasis.	The same word or phrase at the BEGINNING of successive lines or clauses.	The same word or words at the END of successive lines or clauses.	A line or phrase repeated at regular intervals, usually at the end of each stanza.
Position	Anywhere	Start of lines	End of lines	End of stanzas, again and again
Test	Something is said again, and no more exact type fits.	Cover the line endings: do the openings match?	Cover the line openings: do the endings match?	Does it come back stanza after stanza, like a chorus?
Easy example	Water, water, everywhere.	Every day I read, every day I write, every day I improve.	Government of the people, by the people, for the people.	The chorus of a song that returns after every stanza.
From the poems	"And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep." (Stopping by Woods - a whole line said twice)	"We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit" (The Secret of the Machines)	"The brave man never is freed of it. / He has it when there is no need of it." (Courage - of it ends both lines)	"Because it hung behind him." ... "The pigtail hangs behind him." (A Tragic Story - every stanza; some keys call it epistrophe)
Remember	Anaphora, epistrophe and refrain are all TYPES of repetition - choose the most exact option offered. A whole line said again (Stopping by Woods) stays Repetition: not anaphora, not refrain.			

And though his efforts never slack,
And though he twist and twirl, and tack,
 Alas! Still faithful to his back,
 The pigtail hangs *behind him*.

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Anaphora — And though begins two lines in a row. **Refrain — behind him** ends this stanza and every other stanza of the poem. Both are types of **Repetition**.

MEMORY TRICK: ANaphora is At the stArt; EPIstrophe is at the End; a REFRAIN Returns after every stanza; plain Repetition can sit anywhere.

6.7 Oxymoron vs Paradox vs Antithesis HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Oxymoron (4.3)	Paradox (4.11)	Antithesis (4.12)
Meaning	Two contradictory WORDS placed side by side.	A STATEMENT that seems to contradict itself but contains a truth.	Opposite IDEAS placed side by side in balanced words.
Size	Two words, usually adjective + noun	A whole sentence or idea	Two balanced halves (A ... B)

Basis	Oxymoron (4.3)	Paradox (4.11)	Antithesis (4.12)
Is there a contradiction?	Yes - between two touching words.	It only SEEMS so; think again and it is true.	No - only a sharp contrast; both halves are true.
Test	Are the two opposite words TOUCHING?	Does it sound impossible at first, then make sense?	Are two opposites set like a see-saw, in matching grammar?
Easy example	deafening silence; open secret; sweet sorrow	Less is more.	Speech is silver, silence is golden.
From the poems	<i>"and it's empty joy they find,"</i> (The Stick-together Families - empty joy)	<i>"Seeming still, yet still in motion,"</i> (The River)	<i>"I told my wrath, my wrath did end."</i> vs <i>"I told it not, my wrath did grow."</i> (A Poison Tree); <i>"For the battle is lost or the battle is won"</i> (Team Work)

*Seeming **still**, **yet** still in **motion**,*

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Paradox — the deep river looks **still** (not moving), **yet** it is always in **motion**. It sounds impossible but is true. The opposite words are spread across a statement, so it is not an oxymoron, which needs two clashing words side by side (**empty joy**).

MEMORY TRICK: OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): two clashing WORDS; PARADOX: a whole sentence that seems false but is true; ANTI-thesis: opposites balanced like a see-saw.

6.8 Hyperbole vs Litotes vs Euphemism

Basis	Hyperbole (4.7)	Litotes (4.8)	Euphemism (4.9)
Meaning	Deliberate, obvious exaggeration.	Understatement using a negative: "not" + the opposite idea.	A mild word or phrase for something harsh or unpleasant.
Direction	Makes it BIGGER	Makes it sound SMALLER	Makes it SOFTER
Clue words	Huge numbers and extremes: a thousand times mountains of a ton of forever	not no un- + the opposite: not bad no small unreluctant	Gentle words for death, illness or failure: passed away is no more depart sleep
Test	Taken literally, is it impossible?	Drop the "not" and use the opposite word: is that the real meaning?	Is a harsh fact hidden behind a polite phrase?
Easy example	I have told you a thousand times!	Your idli is not bad at all. (= very good)	Grandfather passed away last year. (= died)
From the poems	<i>"And inside you can tell it has a ton of space,"</i> (The House on Elm Street)	<i>"unreluctant soul"</i> (Life - not unwilling = eager)	<i>"They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!"</i> (The Spider and the Fly - they die)

The sands of life are nearly run,

*Let such in **peace depart**!*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Euphemism — for old people near death: **in peace depart** = die peacefully. A soft phrase hides a harsh fact; nothing is made bigger (hyperbole) and there is no "not + opposite" (litotes). **The sands of life** is a metaphor from the hourglass.

MEMORY TRICK: HYPERbole goes over the top; LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"; EUPhemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact.

6.9 Metonymy vs Synecdoche HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Metonymy (4.15)	Synecdoche (4.16)
Meaning	Naming something by a closely ASSOCIATED (linked) thing.	A PART is used for the whole, or the whole for a part.
Link	The named thing is OUTSIDE the real thing but connected to it: worn, used or found with it.	The named thing is a PIECE of the real thing (or the real thing is a piece of it).
Test	Is X a part of Y? NO, only connected = Metonymy.	Is X a part of Y? YES = Synecdoche.

Basis	Metonymy (4.15)	Synecdoche (4.16)
Easy example	The pen is mightier than the sword. (pen = writing; sword = war); The crown ruled the land. (crown = the king)	All hands on deck! (hands = sailors); India won the match. (the whole country for the team: whole for part)
From the poems	" <i>Beneath all uniforms,</i> " (No Men are Foreign - uniforms = soldiers)	" <i>Their hands are ours,</i> " (No Men are Foreign - hands = workers); " <i>Every soul that touches yours</i> -" (Making Life Worth While - soul = person); " <i>It's the old home roof that shelters all the charm that life can give,</i> " (The Stick-together Families - roof = home)
If both fit	Synecdoche is a special kind of metonymy. When a PART is named, the exact answer is Synecdoche.	

*Beneath all **uniforms**, a single body breathes*

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Metonymy — **uniforms** stands for the soldiers who wear them. A uniform is linked to a soldier but is not a part of his body. Compare "*Their hands are ours,*" (5.5): hands ARE a part of the workers, so that line is **Synecdoche**.

MEMORY TRICK: Synecdoche = Some part for the whole; Metonymy = Mention a related thing.

6.10 Irony vs Sarcasm vs Pun

Basis	Irony (4.10)	Sarcasm (4.10)	Pun (4.14)
Meaning	The opposite of what is said or expected: the words mean the opposite (verbal irony), or events turn out the opposite (situational irony).	Bitter verbal irony meant to hurt or mock a person.	A play on two meanings of one word, or on two words that sound alike.
Tone	Can be serious, sad or funny	Sharp and mocking - it stings	Light and clever - it makes you smile
Test	Is the real meaning or result the OPPOSITE of the surface?	Is that opposite aimed at someone, to wound?	Can ONE word be read two ways at the same time?
Easy example	The fire station burned down. / "Lovely weather!" said in a cyclone.	To a friend who is an hour late: "Wow, you are so early!"	A bicycle cannot stand on its own because it is two-tired (too tired).
From the poems	" <i>I'm your servant and friend, / But we ants never borrow; we ants never lend.</i> " (The Ant and the Cricket - a self-declared friend who refuses help); the title A Tragic Story for a comic tale	" <i>and dance the winter away.</i> " (The Ant and the Cricket - mocking the starving singer)	" <i>Some crickets have four legs, and some have two.</i> " (cricket = insect / idle person); " <i>Then my computer caught a virus, and fell very sick,</i> " (computer virus / illness)

"You sang, Sir, you say?

Go then," says the ant, "and **dance the winter away.**"

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Sarcasm — the ant mocks the starving cricket: you sang all summer, so now dance through the winter! It sounds like advice but is meant to sting. A few lines earlier, "*I'm your servant and friend,*" followed by a flat refusal is **irony**; the last line, about crickets with two legs, is a **pun**.

MEMORY TRICK: Irony says the opposite; Sarcasm says the opposite to HURT (irony with teeth); a Pun gives one word two jobs.

6.11 Allusion vs Illusion vs Delusion (vocabulary trap)

Basis	Allusion (4.2)	Illusion	Delusion
Meaning	A brief reference to a well-known person, place, event, story or text.	A false picture: something that LOOKS or SEEMS real but is not (the senses are fooled).	A false BELIEF held firmly even when the facts show it is wrong (the mind is fooled).
Figure of speech?	YES (see 4.2)	NO - an ordinary noun	NO - an ordinary noun
Clue	A famous name or story in a few words: the Bible, the epics, history, literature.	Eyes and senses: a mirage, a magic trick, an optical illusion.	Mind and belief: a false idea a person will not give up.
Easy example	My brother is a real Kumbhakarna on holidays. (the giant of the Ramayana famous for his long sleep)	The water you see far ahead on a hot road is an illusion (a mirage).	He has the delusion that he can pass without studying.
From the poems	" <i>Till it bore an apple bright.</i> " (A Poison Tree - the forbidden fruit of Eden); " <i>Said to them, 'Peace, be still.'</i> " (Your Space - the Bible)	Word sense only: " <i>Seeming still, yet still in motion,</i> " (The River) - the river's stillness is an illusion.	Word sense only: " <i>And swore he'd change the pigtail's place,</i> " (A Tragic Story) - the sage's firm false belief is a comic delusion.

Basis	Allusion (4.2)	Illusion	Delusion
Exam use	"Identify the figure of speech"	Vocabulary: The magician created an _____. (illusion)	Vocabulary: He lives under the _____ that he is always right. (delusion)

And it grew both day and night,
Till it bore an **apple bright**.
A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Allusion — the shining apple recalls the forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden: a famous story brought in with two words. An allusion REFERS; an illusion only fools the eye and a delusion fools the mind — those two are vocabulary words, not figures of speech.

MEMORY TRICK: ALLusion: ALL readers know the story it refers to; ILLusion: the eye is ILL (fooled); DELusion: the mind is DEceived.

6.12 Rhyme vs Rhyme Scheme vs Rhythm

Basis	Rhyme (3.9)	Rhyme scheme (3.8)	Rhythm
Meaning	Words whose last sounds match, usually the words at the end of lines.	The PATTERN of end rhymes in a stanza, marked with small letters a, b, c ...	The BEAT of a line: the pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables.
Your answer looks like	A set of words: know - though - snow	Letters: aaba	Beats: the number of strong stresses, e.g. 4 beats a line
How to find	Read the last word of each line aloud; match the sounds from the last vowel.	First end-sound = a. Same sound again = same letter. New end-sound = next letter.	Read aloud and tap the strong syllables; count the taps in each line.
Easy example	star - are; high - sky	Twinkle, twinkle, little star / How I wonder what you are / Up above the world so high / Like a diamond in the sky = aabb	TWIN-kle, TWIN-kle, LIT-tle STAR = 4 beats
From the poems	lake - shake - mistake - flake (Stopping by Woods); sky - by (Sea Fever)	Stopping by Woods = aaba bcbcb cddc dddd; Life = abbaabba cddcee; The River = abccb	"Faster than fairies, faster than witches," (From a Railway Carriage) - the galloping beat copies the rattle of the train.
Free verse	No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree and Making Life Worth While have no regular end rhyme: the answer is "free verse, no rhyme scheme". Free verse has no fixed beat either.		

We can pull and haul and push and lift and **drive**,
We can print and plough and weave and heat and **light**,
We can run and race and swim and fly and **dive**,
We can see and hear and count and read and **write**!
THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Rhyme — drive - dive and light - write. **Rhyme scheme** — abab. **Rhythm** — five strong beats in every line (we can PULL and HAUL and PUSH and LIFT and DRIVE), steady like a machine at work.

MEMORY TRICK: Rhyme = the SOUND (words); Rhyme scheme = the PATTERN (letters); Rhythm = the BEAT (claps). New end-sound = new letter.

6.13 Imagery vs Symbolism vs Metaphor

Basis	Imagery (4.26)	Symbolism (4.26)	Metaphor (3.3)
Meaning	Words that appeal to the senses - sight, sound, smell, taste, touch - and paint a picture.	A real object that also STANDS FOR an idea. It stays itself but carries a bigger meaning.	One thing is said to BE another (an implied comparison).
Question it answers	What do I see, hear, smell, taste or feel?	What does this object stand for?	What is compared to what?
Test	Can you picture it with your senses? Nothing needs to be compared.	Is the object real in the scene, yet pointing to an idea (peace, death, duty)?	Is A called B, though A is not literally B?
Easy example	Golden sand, salty wind and roaring waves at the Marina.	In a story, a lamp burning in a dark hut stands for hope.	Hope is a lamp.
From the poems	"The source, white and wet," (On Killing a Tree - sight, touch); "monsoons and mangoes / leapfrogs and roads" (Indian Seasons - sight)	The apple in A Poison Tree (deceit); the river's journey to the sea in The River (the stages of human life)	"And hope the road's last turn will be the best." (Life - the end of life is the road's last turn)

Basis	Imagery (4.26)	Symbolism (4.26)	Metaphor (3.3)
Key difference	Imagery works on the SENSES; a symbol is a real THING with a hidden meaning; a metaphor needs a COMPARISON. The same lines can show all three (see the card below).		

The woods are *lovely, dark and deep*,

But I have *promises* to keep,

And miles to go before I *sleep*,

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Imagery — *lovely, dark and deep* lets you SEE the woods. **Symbolism** — the woods stand for rest or temptation, the *promises* for duties. **Metaphor** — *sleep* means death, the long rest at the end of life's journey.

MEMORY TRICK: Imagery = I sense it; Symbol = it Stands for an idea; Metaphor = it Means "is" (a comparison).

6.14 False Similes: when "like" or "as" is not a simile

A true simile needs three things: (1) a comparing word, (2) two UNLIKE things, (3) an imaginative point. "Like" and "as" also do ordinary jobs - as a verb, as "when", as "such as", and in plain measurement - so check all three before you answer Simile.

Sentence	Simile? (Yes / No)	Why
I like idli.	No	"like" is a verb (= enjoy). Nothing is compared.
As I reached home, it rained.	No	"as" means "when" - it only tells the time.
She is as tall as her brother.	No	A plain, literal measurement of two people - no imagination.
Do as I say.	No	"as" means "in the way that" - an order, not a comparison.
Fruits like mango and guava are sweet.	No	"like" means "such as" - it only gives examples.
The ball flew to the boundary like a bullet.	Yes	A cricket ball is compared with a bullet: unlike things, joined by "like".
"Like a child at play." (The River)	Yes	The young, playful river is compared with a child.
"where the wind's like a whetted knife;" (Sea Fever)	Yes	The cutting sea wind is compared with a sharpened knife.
"Faster than a cheetah" (The Comet)	Yes	A comet is compared with a cheetah using "than": textbook keys count it as a simile.
"a single body breathes / Like ours" (No Men are Foreign)	Yes (exam key)	People are compared with people, but not to measure them: the point is that the "enemy" breathes just as we do. Exam keys call it a simile - learn it as the exception.

All of the sights of the hill and the plain

Fly *as* thick *as* driving rain;

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

A true "as ... as" simile — the sights flashing past the train are compared with **driving rain**: two UNLIKE things, compared to make a picture. "She is as tall as her brother" uses the same pattern only to measure two people, so it is NOT a simile.

MEMORY TRICK: Before you tick Simile, ask: comparing word? unlike things? imaginative? Three Yes = Simile.

6.15 Master Summary

Pair	The one-line difference
Simile vs Metaphor	Simile compares WITH like / as / than; metaphor says A IS B with no comparing word.
Metaphor vs Personification	A metaphor turns a thing into any other thing; personification turns it into a PERSON.
Personification vs Apostrophe	Personification talks ABOUT a thing as if it were human; apostrophe talks TO someone absent or to a thing (you, O).
Alliteration vs Assonance vs Consonance	Same first consonant sound / same vowel sound / same consonant sound inside or at the end.
Alliteration vs Onomatopoeia	Alliteration repeats first sounds across words; onomatopoeia is one word that sounds like its meaning.
Repetition vs Anaphora vs Epistrophe vs Refrain	Repeated anywhere / at the start of lines / at the end of lines / at the end of every stanza.

Pair	The one-line difference
Oxymoron vs Paradox vs Antithesis	Two clashing words side by side / a statement that seems false but is true / opposite ideas in balance.
Hyperbole vs Litotes vs Euphemism	Makes it bigger / makes it smaller with "not" / makes a harsh fact softer.
Metonymy vs Synecdoche	Metonymy names a linked thing (uniforms = soldiers); synecdoche names a part for the whole (hands = workers).
Irony vs Sarcasm vs Pun	The opposite meaning / the opposite meaning used to hurt / one word with two meanings.
Allusion vs Illusion vs Delusion	Allusion refers to a famous story (a figure of speech); illusion fools the eye and delusion fools the mind (vocabulary only).
Rhyme vs Rhyme Scheme vs Rhythm	Matching end sounds (words) / the pattern of those sounds (letters) / the beat of the line (stresses).
Imagery vs Symbolism vs Metaphor	Appeals to the senses / a real object standing for an idea / one thing called another.
True simile vs False simile	A true simile compares two unlike things imaginatively; "I like idli", "As I reached home" and "as tall as her brother" are not similes.

MUST REMEMBER: When two options both fit, choose the MORE EXACT one: Personification over Metaphor, Anaphora over Repetition, Synecdoche over Metonymy when a PART is named, Apostrophe when the thing is spoken TO. But a whole line said again (Stopping by Woods) stays Repetition.

MUST REMEMBER: Clue words are hints, not proof. "Like" and "as" can be a verb, "when" or "such as"; opposite words side by side = Oxymoron, spread across a true-but-strange statement = Paradox, balanced halves = Antithesis. Always test the MEANING before you answer.

9 Final Revision Sheet

This is your one-sitting revision before the exam. Nothing here is new: every row points back to the full notes in Sections 3 to 7. Read each table row by row, say every poem line aloud, then cover the right-hand columns and test yourself.

9.1 All 36 Figures on One Page

All 36 figures, grouped by the 7 families of Section 2. The 9 syllabus figures carry the

IN SYLLABUS badge; the other 27 are explained in Section 4. The last column tells you where the full card is.

MEMORY TRICK: The 9 syllabus figures: "A Smart Monkey Plays On A Rainy Rocky Road" = Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme scheme, Rhyming words.

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
A. Comparison — 5 figures				
Simile IN SYLLABUS	like as ... as as if than joining two UNLIKE things	Simile Says "like"	Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	3.2
Metaphor IN SYLLABUS	is are was A is B, with no like / as	Metaphor Means "is"	Our classroom is a zoo when the teacher is away.	3.3
Personification IN SYLLABUS	a thing, animal or idea + a human action or feeling: smiles thinks sits	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON	The sun smiled on the paddy fields.	3.4
Apostrophe	0 ...! you said to someone absent or dead, or to a thing or idea	APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply	Twinkle, twinkle, little star, how I wonder what you are!	4.1
Extended Metaphor and Allegory	one comparison kept up over many lines; a whole story with a hidden moral	one metaphor, many lines; allegory = a story with a lesson inside	Life is a cricket match: we bat, we field, we play till the last over. Allegory: The Hare and the Tortoise.	4.27
B. Sound — 6 figures				
Alliteration IN SYLLABUS	same first SOUND (usually a consonant) in nearby words	ALL-ITERATION: ALL start with the same SOUND — say it aloud	Big black buffaloes block the busy bazaar.	3.1

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
Assonance	same VOWEL sound repeated in nearby words	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U)	Go slow over the road. (long o)	4.5
Consonance	same CONSONANT sound, usually inside or at the end of words	CONSONANCE = consonants	Mike struck the black rock. (k)	4.6
Onomatopoeia IN SYLLABUS	buzz click hiss whistle snap bang	the word makes the sound it names	The pressure cooker whistled three times.	3.5
Rhyme Scheme IN SYLLABUS	small letters a b c for the line-end sounds	New end-sound = new letter	star - are - high - sky = aabb (Twinkle, twinkle)	3.8
Rhyming Words IN SYLLABUS	same last sound, usually the line-end words; near rhymes accepted	rhyme by ear, not by eye	cat - mat; light - night; blue - shoe	3.9
C. Repetition and order — 9 figures				
Anaphora IN SYLLABUS	same word or phrase at the START of lines or clauses	ANaphora is At the sTart	We shall study, we shall work, we shall win.	3.6
Repetition IN SYLLABUS	same word, phrase or line again, anywhere, for emphasis	same word again, anywhere	It is a long, long way to Kanyakumari.	3.7
Epistrophe	same word or words at the END of lines or clauses	EPistrophe is at the End	government of the people, by the people, for the people	4.21
Refrain	a line or phrase that comes back at regular places, usually each stanza end	refrain = the chorus	the chorus that returns after every stanza of a film song	4.22
Polysyndeton and Asyndeton	and ... and ... and / only commas, no and	POLY = many "and"s; A-syndeton = "and" Absent	We ate idli and dosa and vada and pongal. / I came, I saw, I conquered.	4.23
Chiasmus	criss-cross order: A B ... B A	Chi = X: the words cross over	Eat to live; do not live to eat.	4.24
Inversion	normal word order reversed: verb, object or adjective comes first	sentence turned around	Down came the rain.	4.20
Climax and Anticlimax	ideas rising step by step / a sudden drop to something small	climax climbs; anticlimax falls flat	He lost his job, his home, his family. / He lost his job, his home and his pencil.	4.25
Ellipsis	words left out that the reader supplies; the mark ...	a missing piece the reader fills in	Some like tea; others, coffee. (like left out)	4.4
D. Contrast — 4 figures				
Oxymoron	two opposite words side by side	OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): the word is itself an oxymoron	deafening silence; open secret; bitter-sweet	4.3
Paradox	a whole statement that seems false but holds a truth	sounds wrong, proves right	You have to be cruel to be kind.	4.11
Antithesis	opposite ideas placed side by side in balanced words	opposites on a see-saw	It was the best of times, it was the worst of times.	4.12
Epigram	a short, witty, memorable saying	a one-line quotable gem	Brevity is the soul of wit.	4.13
E. Exaggeration and understatement — 3 figures				
Hyperbole	a thousand a ton of mountains of forever	HYPERbole goes over the top	I am so hungry I could eat a hundred idlis.	4.7
Litotes and Understatement	not bad not unkind no small ; a big thing made to sound small	LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"	Ninety-nine in maths? Not bad! / Chennai in May is a little warm.	4.8
Euphemism	passed away let go differently abled	EUphemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact	Grandfather passed away last year.	4.9
F. Indirect meaning — 4 figures				

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
Irony and Sarcasm	the opposite of what is said or expected; sarcasm = bitter irony meant to hurt	irony says the opposite; sarcasm stings	The fire station burnt down. / "Oh, great — another power cut!"	4.10
Pun	one word (or sound) with two meanings	one word, double duty	A bicycle cannot stand alone because it is two-tired.	4.14
Rhetorical Question	a ? with no answer expected	asked for effect, not for an answer	Who does not love a holiday?	4.18
Exclamation	Oh! Alas! Hurrah! What a ...!	"!" = strong feeling	Hurrah! We won the match!	4.19
G. Association and reference — 5 figures				
Allusion	a brief mention of a famous person, place, event, story or text	a quick nod to a famous story	Wake up, Kumbhakarna — it is nine o'clock!	4.2
Metonymy	a related thing names the idea: crown pen uniforms	Metonymy = Mention a related thing	The pen is mightier than the sword.	4.15
Synecdoche	a part for the whole, or the whole for a part: hands wheels roof	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole	The farmer hired ten hands for the harvest.	4.16
Transferred Epithet	a person's feeling-word put on a thing: busy day sleepless night	the night was not sleepless — YOU were	I spent a sleepless night before the exam.	4.17
Imagery and Symbolism	words for the senses (see hear smell touch taste) / an object that stands for an idea	imagery = senses; symbol = a thing that stands for an idea	the smell of hot sambar and golden, crisp dosas (imagery); a white dove = peace (symbol)	4.26

9.2 The 25 Poems at a Glance

No. is also the poem's number in Section 5 (No. 7 = 5.7). The rhyme schemes are the ones used everywhere in this book; the figures are the two or three most important in each poem. Cover the last two columns and recall them for each poem before you look.

No.	Poem	Poet	Rhyme scheme	Top figures
1	Life	Henry Van Dyke	abbaabba cddcee (sonnet)	Alliteration ("forward face"); Metaphor , life as a journey ("the journey will be joy"); Litotes ("unreluctant soul" = eager)
2	I am Every Woman	Rakhi Nariani Shirke	no regular scheme	Metaphor ("She's a lioness"); Alliteration ("faith, firm"); Onomatopoeia ("sighs and groans and moans")
3	The Secret of the Machines	Rudyard Kipling	abab	Anaphora ("We were" ... "We can"); Personification (the machines speak); Alliteration ("print and plough")
4	The Ant and the Cricket	adapted from Aesop's fables	aabb (couplets; a few triplets)	Personification (a talking ant and cricket in a fable); Anaphora ("Not a flower" / "Not a leaf"); Alliteration ("silly young cricket, accustomed to sing")
5	No Men are Foreign	James Falconer Kirkup	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Simile ("eyes like ours"; see 3.2); Repetition (first and last lines); Metonymy ("uniforms" = soldiers)
6	The House on Elm Street	Nadia Bush	no regular scheme	Personification ("It sat alone."); Hyperbole ("a ton of space"); Rhetorical question ("How could this be?")
7	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Robert Frost	aaba bbbcb cddc dddd	Repetition ("And miles to go before I sleep", twice); Personification ("My little horse must think it queer"); Alliteration ("watch his woods")
8	A Poison Tree	William Blake	aabb	Extended metaphor , anger as a tree ("And I water'd it in fears."); Anaphora ("I was angry"); Allusion ("an apple bright" = the forbidden fruit)
9	On Killing a Tree	Gieve Patel	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Metaphor ("leperous hide"); Alliteration ("bleeding bark"); Irony (the whole poem reads like cold instructions for killing)
10	The Spider and the Fly	Mary Botham Howitt	aabb	Personification (a talking spider and fly; allegory of the flatterer); Repetition ("Oh no, no"); Euphemism ("never, never wake again" = die)
11	The River	Caroline Ann Bowles	abccb (every stanza)	Apostrophe + Personification ("River, river, little river!"); Simile ("Like a child at play"); Paradox ("Seeming still, yet still in motion")
12	The Comet	Norman Littleford	abcb	Simile ("Faster than a cheetah"); Personification ("Rampaging through the heavens"); Repetition ("a comet in full flight", lines 4 and 24)

No.	Poem	Poet	Rhyme scheme	Top figures
13	The Stick-together Families	Edgar Albert Guest	aabb	Oxymoron (“empty joy”); Transferred epithet (“the busy day”); Apostrophe (“O weary, wandering brother”)
14	Special Hero	Christina M. Kerschen	abcb	Metaphor (“my special hero”); Rhetorical question (“How did I get so lucky”)
15	Making Life Worth While	George Eliot	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Anaphora (“One bit of courage ... One gleam of faith”); Metaphor (“the darkening sky” = hard times); Synecdoche (“Every soul” = every person)
16	A Thing of Beauty	John Keats	aabb (heroic couplets)	Epigram (“A thing of beauty is a joy for ever”); Metaphor (“An endless fountain of immortal drink”); Alliteration (“band to bind”)
17	Lessons in Life	Brigitte Bryant and Daniel Ho	abcb (verses); chorus free - me	Simile (“like planting a flower”); Refrain (the chorus “Lessons in life aren't always so simple”)
18	My Computer Needs a Break	Shanthini Govindan	aabb	Personification (“so brainy and smart”); Hyperbole (“mountains of information”); Onomatopoeia (“click”)
19	Your Space	David Bates	abab	Anaphora (“Speak gently” opens the stanzas); Personification (“Affection's voice is kind.”); Allusion (“Peace, be still.” — the Bible, the calming of the storm)
20	Sea Fever	John Masefield	aabb	Alliteration (“a star to steer her by”); Anaphora (“I must go down to the seas again”); Simile (“the wind's like a whetted knife”)
21	Courage	Edgar Albert Guest	aabb	Alliteration (“A daring deed”); Anaphora (“It isn't” ... “It's part of”); Metaphor (“the breath of life”)
22	Team Work	Edgar Albert Guest	abab	Metaphor , life as a game (“no lone hand in the game we play”); Anaphora (“They may”); Antithesis (“the battle is lost or the battle is won”)
23	From a Railway Carriage	Robert Louis Stevenson	aabb	Alliteration (“Faster than fairies”); Simile (“like troops in a battle”); Personification (“Painted stations whistle by”)
24	Indian Seasons	Nisha Dyrene	abcb	Personification (Summer with “sunny smiles / and dusty feet”); Alliteration (“monsoons and mangoes”); Anaphora (“Autumn is English” ... “Autumn is Indian”)
25	A Tragic Story	William Makepeace Thackeray	aaab cccb ddb eebb fffb gggb	Refrain / Epistrophe (“behind him” closes every stanza); Irony (a comic tale with a “tragic” title); Alliteration (“curious case”)

EXAM TIP: Learn the rhyme schemes in groups. **aabb (9):** The Ant and the Cricket, A Poison Tree, The Spider and the Fly, The Stick-together Families, A Thing of Beauty, My Computer Needs a Break, Sea Fever, Courage, From a Railway Carriage. **abab (3):** The Secret of the Machines, Your Space, Team Work. **abcb (4):** The Comet, Special Hero, Lessons in Life (verses), Indian Seasons. **Free verse (3):** No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree, Making Life Worth While. **No regular scheme (2):** I am Every Woman, The House on Elm Street. **One of a kind (4):** Life (abbaabba cddcee), Stopping by Woods (aaba bbcb ccdb dddd), The River (abccb), A Tragic Story (aaab cccb ddb eebb fffb gggb).

9.3 Top 30 Lines Most Likely to Be Asked

Exact lines from 25 poems, in syllabus order. The highlighted words are the clue. A line can hold more than one figure; the answer given is the one the highlighted clue points to, and it matches the rest of this book. Cover the Figure column, read each line aloud and name the figure in 10 seconds.

No.	Line	Poem	Figure
1	With f orward f ace and unreluctant soul;	Life	Alliteration (f - f)
2	She's a lioness ; don't mess with her.	I am Every Woman	Metaphor — she IS a lioness; no like / as
3	We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit	The Secret of the Machines	Anaphora — same start, line after line
4	Not a flower could he see, / Not a leaf on a tree.	The Ant and the Cricket	Anaphora — same start, line after line
5	Remember they have eyes like ours that wake	No Men are Foreign	Simile — comparison with like; the textbook answer (see 3.2)
6	It sat alone .	The House on Elm Street	Personification — a house given a human action
7	My little horse must think it queer	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Personification — a horse given human thoughts

No.	Line	Poem	Figure
8	<i>And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.</i>	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Repetition — not anaphora, not refrain
9	And I <i>water'd it</i> in fears,	A Poison Tree	Metaphor — anger is a tree he waters (extended metaphor)
10	And out of its <i>leperous hide</i>	On Killing a Tree	Metaphor — the bark is called a diseased skin
11	Said the <i>cunning Spider</i> to the Fly,	The Spider and the Fly	Personification — a spider that talks and plots
12	<i>River, river</i> , little river! / Bright <i>you sparkle</i> on your way;	The River	Apostrophe + Personification — the river is spoken to directly and treated as a living person
13	<i>Like</i> a child at play.	The River	Simile — the young river is compared to a playing child
14	<i>Seeming still</i> , yet <i>still in motion</i> ,	The River	Paradox — still and moving at once: seems false, is true
15	<i>Faster than</i> a cheetah	The Comet	Simile — comparison with than (see 3.2)
16	and it's <i>empty joy</i> they find,	The Stick-together Families	Oxymoron — two opposite words side by side
17	<i>How did I get so lucky</i> ,	Special Hero	Rhetorical question — wonder, no answer expected
18	<i>One</i> bit of courage ... <i>One</i> gleam of faith ... <i>One</i> glimpse of brighter skies	Making Life Worth While	Anaphora — One ... One ... One
19	An endless <i>fountain</i> of immortal drink,	A Thing of Beauty	Metaphor — beauty is an endless fountain
20	Having a friend is <i>like</i> planting a flower	Lessons in Life	Simile — friendship compared to planting a flower
21	and give my mouse a <i>click</i> ,	My Computer Needs a Break	Onomatopoeia — the word is the sound itself
22	<i>Speak gently</i> to the little child! ... <i>Speak gently</i> to the young, for they	Your Space	Anaphora — the stanzas open with the same words
23	And all I ask is a tall ship and a <i>star</i> to <i>steer</i> her by;	Sea Fever	Alliteration (st - st)
24	A <i>daring deed</i> in a moment's flash;	Courage	Alliteration (d - d)
25	For there's <i>no lone hand in the game</i> we play,	Team Work	Metaphor — life and work are a game played as a team
26	<i>Faster than</i> <i>fairies</i> , <i>faster than</i> witches,	From a Railway Carriage	Alliteration (f - f - f) — the safest single answer; it is also simile and hyperbole (see 3.2, 7.5)
27	And charging along <i>like</i> troops in a battle,	From a Railway Carriage	Simile — the horses and cattle seem to charge along like troops
28	<i>m</i> onsoons and <i>m</i> angoes	Indian Seasons	Alliteration (m - m)
29	He mused upon this <i>c</i> urious <i>c</i> ase,	A Tragic Story	Alliteration (k sound: c - c)
30	Because it hung <i>behind him</i> Not dangling there <i>behind him</i> .	A Tragic Story	Refrain / Epistrophe — the same words close every stanza

DO NOT CONFUSE: three trap lines. “Whose woods these are I think I know.” is inversion, not alliteration (h sound + w sound). “simple sheep” and “short and sweet” are not alliteration (s and sh are different sounds). “Painted stations whistle by.” is personification (the stations act) and also onomatopoeia (whistle), so answer the one the question highlights.

9.4 The 10-Second Method: Recap

Ask these ten questions in this order, as in 7.2. Tick every "yes", then match your ticks with the options; when two or more fit, answer the one the question points to (7.5).

1. **Sound-word?** buzz, click, whistle, snap → **Onomatopoeia**.
2. **Same first sound** in nearby words? Say it aloud → **Alliteration**. Same vowel sound → Assonance; same consonant inside or at the end → Consonance.
3. **like / as / as ... as / than** joining two UNLIKE things → **Simile**.
4. **A is B**, with no like / as → **Metaphor**; kept up over many lines → Extended metaphor.
5. **Thing acting human** (thinks, smiles, sits, speaks) → **Personification**.

6. **Addressing the absent** — a dead or absent person, a thing or an idea called "you" or "O ... " → **Apostrophe**.
7. **Repeated starts or ends?** Same start → **Anaphora**; same end → Epistrophe; a line back after every stanza → Refrain; the same word or line anywhere → **Repetition**.
8. **Opposites?** Two words side by side → Oxymoron; balanced opposite ideas → Antithesis; a whole statement that seems false but is true → Paradox.
9. **Exaggeration or understatement?** Over the top → Hyperbole; "not bad" for "good" → Litotes; a soft word for a harsh fact → Euphemism.
10. **Reference or omission?** A famous person or story → Allusion; words left out that you can supply → Ellipsis.

9.5 Ten Golden Rules

1. **Alliteration is sound, not letter.** "*keep the courage of the quest*" repeats the k sound, so it is alliteration; "*Whose woods*" is h + w, so it is NOT.
2. **like / as must compare two UNLIKE things.** "I like mangoes" and "She is as tall as her brother" are not similes. A "than" comparison also counts: "*Faster than a cheetah*" = simile.
3. **Anaphora = same START of lines.** "*We were taken*" ... "*We were melted*" = anaphora. A whole line said twice ("*And miles to go before I sleep*") = repetition. Same END = epistrophe; a line after every stanza = refrain.
4. **Apostrophe needs the absent or a thing.** "*River, river, little river!*" = apostrophe (+ personification). Talking to a doctor who is in the room is NOT apostrophe.
5. **Acting human = personification; spoken to = apostrophe.** Talking animals in fables (the spider, the fly, the ant, the cricket) = personification.
6. **Check what the question highlights.** One line can hold two or three figures; the underlined or bold word decides. For "*Faster than fairies, faster than witches*", alliteration is the safest single answer.
7. **Free verse has no rhyme scheme.** No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree and Making Life Worth While are free verse. I am Every Woman and The House on Elm Street have scattered rhymes but no regular scheme.
8. **New sound = new letter.** A sound used before takes its old letter back: Stopping by Woods = aaba bbcb ccdc dddd.
9. **Rhyme by ear, not by eye.** Near rhymes such as arms - harm, smooth - youth and scheme - team are accepted in textbook answers.
10. **Oxymoron = two words; paradox = a whole statement.** "*empty joy*" = oxymoron; "*Seeming still, yet still in motion*" = paradox.

9.6 Last Word Before the Exam

MUST REMEMBER: say every line aloud, because sound, not spelling, decides alliteration; like / as / than between unlike things = simile, "is" = metaphor; a thing acting human = personification, a thing spoken to = apostrophe; same start = anaphora, the same line again = repetition; free verse has no rhyme scheme, and every new end-sound takes a new letter; when a line holds two figures, answer the one the question highlights.

Figures of Speech Master Notes — TNPSC General English. Poem texts follow the Tamil Nadu Samacheer Kalvi textbook versions; every quotation was checked word for word.

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